23 CRUDE OIL

The oil industry is at the very heart of modern life. It provides fuels, plastics and the organic chemicals which go to make things as different as solvents, drugs, dyes and explosives. This chapter explores how an unappealing, sticky, black liquid is converted into useful things.



▲ Figure 23.1 The oil industry is BIG business!

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Know that crude oil is a mixture of hydrocarbons
- Describe how the industrial process of fractional distillation separates crude oil into fractions
- Know the names and uses of the main fractions obtained from crude oil: refinery gases, gasoline, kerosene, diesel, fuel oil and bitumen
- Know the trend in colour, boiling point and viscosity of the main fractions
- Know that a fuel is a substance that, when burned, releases heat energy
- Know the possible products of complete and incomplete combustion of hydrocarbons with oxygen in the air
- Know that in car engines the temperature reached is high enough to allow nitrogen and oxygen from air to react, forming oxides of nitrogen
- Explain how the combustion of some impurities in hydrocarbon fuels results in the formation of sulfur dioxide
- Understand how sulfur dioxide and oxides of nitrogen contribute to acid rain
- Describe how long-chain alkanes are converted to alkenes and shorter-chain alkanes by catalytic cracking (using silica or alumina as the catalyst and a temperature in the range of 600–700 °C)
- Explain why cracking is necessary in terms of the balance between supply and demand for different fractions

WHAT IS CRUDE OIL?

THE ORIGIN OF CRUDE OIL

Millions of years ago, plants and animals living in the sea died and fell to the bottom. Layers of sediment formed on top of them. Their shells and skeletons formed limestone. The soft tissue was gradually changed by heat and high pressure into **crude oil**. Crude oil is a *finite, non-renewable resource*. Once all the existing supplies have been used, they won't be replaced, or at least not for many millions of years.



▲ Figure 23.2 This sticky black liquid is essential to modern life.

CRUDE OIL CONTAINS HYDROCARBONS

Crude oil is a mixture of hydrocarbons, *compounds containing carbon and hydrogen only*. There are lots of different hydrocarbons of various sizes in crude oil, ranging from molecules with just a few carbon and hydrogen atoms to molecules containing over 100 atoms.

HOW THE PHYSICAL PROPERTIES OF HYDROCARBONS CHANGE WITH MOLECULE SIZE

As the number of carbon atoms in hydrocarbon molecules increases, the physical properties of the compounds change. Most of these changes are the result of increasing attractions between neighbouring molecules. *As the molecules become bigger, the intermolecular forces of attraction become stronger* and it becomes more difficult to pull one molecule away from its neighbours.

REMINDER

Intermolecular forces are explained in Chapter 8 (page 92).

As the molecules become bigger, the following changes occur.

- *Boiling point increases*: the larger the molecule, the higher the boiling point. This is because large molecules are attracted to each other more strongly than smaller ones. More energy is needed to break these stronger intermolecular forces of attraction to produce the widely separated molecules in the gas.
- *The liquids become less* **volatile**: the bigger the hydrocarbon, the more slowly it evaporates at room temperature. This is again because the bigger molecules are more strongly attracted to their neighbours and so don't turn into a gas so easily.
- *The liquids become more* **viscous** *and flow less easily*: liquids containing small hydrocarbon molecules are runny. Those containing large molecules flow less easily because of the stronger forces of attraction between their molecules.
- The liquids become darker in colour.
- Bigger hydrocarbons do not burn as easily as smaller ones. This limits the use of the bigger ones as fuels.

HINT

We usually count a substance as being volatile if it turns to a vapour easily at room temperature. That means it will evaporate quickly at that temperature.

SEPARATING CRUDE OIL

Crude oil itself has no uses and it has to be separated into *fractions* before it can be used. These fractions are all mixtures, but each one contains a narrow range of sizes of hydrocarbons with similar boiling points. We use **fractional distillation** to separate crude oil into fractions. This is carried out in an oil refinery.

FRACTIONAL DISTILLATION

Crude oil is heated until it boils and the vapours pass into a **fractionating column**, which is cooler at the top and hotter at the bottom. The vapours rise up the column. How far up the column a particular hydrocarbon moves depends on its boiling point.

KEY POINT

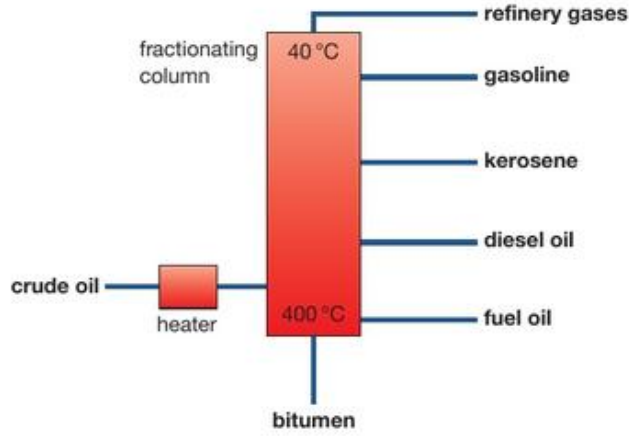
The boiling point is the same as the temperature at which a gas condenses to form a liquid; it could also be called the *condensation point*.

Suppose a hydrocarbon boils at 120 °C. At the bottom of the column, the temperature is much higher than 120 °C and so the hydrocarbon remains as a gas. As it travels up the column, the temperature of the column becomes lower. When the temperature falls to 120 °C, that hydrocarbon will turn into a liquid, it *condenses* and can be removed.

Smaller molecules have lower boiling points and get further up the column before they condense. Longer chain hydrocarbons have higher boiling points and condense lower down in the column. This way, the crude oil is split into various *fractions*.

HINT

You will find a lot of disagreement, from various sources, about exactly what fractions are produced in fractional distillation. Figure 23.3 matches the requirements of the Edexcel International GCSE specification, but this is a major simplification of what really goes on.



▲ Figure 23.3 Fractional distillation of crude oil

The hydrocarbons in the refinery gas fraction (see Figure 23.3) have very small masses and their boiling points are so low that the temperature of the column never falls low enough for them to condense to liquids. The temperature of the column isn't hot enough to boil some of the very large hydrocarbons found in the crude oil, and so they remain as a liquid. These are removed as a residue from the bottom of the column. Bitumen (see below), which is used in road making, is made from this.

USES OF THE FRACTIONS

AS FUELS

All hydrocarbons burn in air (oxygen) to form *carbon dioxide and water*, and release a lot of heat in the process. The various fractions can therefore be used as **fuels**.

A fuel is a substance which, when burned, releases heat energy.

HINT

Don't try to learn these equations as there are too many possible hydrocarbons you could be asked about. Provided you know (or are told) the formula of the fuel and remember the products of the combustion reaction, you can balance the equation yourself.



▲ Figure 23.4 As well as all the other poisonous or cancer-causing compounds, cigarette smoke contains carbon monoxide due to incomplete combustion.

For example, burning methane (the major constituent of natural gas):

$$CH_4(g) + 2O_2(g) \rightarrow CO_2(g) + 2H_2O(l)$$

or burning octane (one of the hydrocarbons present in gasoline, petrol):

$$2C_8H_{18}(l) + 25O_2(g) \rightarrow 16CO_2(g) + 18H_2O(l)$$

If there isn't enough air (or oxygen), you get **incomplete combustion**. This leads to the formation of *carbon (soot)* or *carbon monoxide* instead of carbon dioxide.

For example, if methane burns in a badly maintained gas appliance, there may not be enough oxygen available to produce carbon dioxide, and so you get toxic carbon monoxide instead:

$$2CH_4(g) + 3O_2(g) \rightarrow 2CO(g) + 4H_2O(l)$$

The formation of carbon monoxide from the incomplete combustion of hydrocarbons is very dangerous. Carbon monoxide is colourless and odourless, and is very poisonous. *Carbon monoxide is poisonous because it reduces the ability of the blood to carry oxygen around the body*. This will make you ill, or you may even die, because not enough oxygen gets to the cells in your body for respiration to provide energy.

DID YOU KNOW?

Carbon monoxide combines with *haemoglobin* (the molecule that carries oxygen in the red blood cells), preventing it from carrying the oxygen. It binds more strongly to the haemoglobin than oxygen does.

EXTENSION WORK

If you try to draw a dot-and-cross diagram for carbon monoxide, you will see that it is a very strange molecule because carbon does not form four bonds.

REFINERY GASES

Refinery gases are *a mixture of methane, ethane, propane and butane*, which can be separated into individual gases if required. These gases are commonly used as liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) for domestic heating and cooking.

GASOLINE (PETROL)

As with all the other fractions, petrol is a mixture of hydrocarbons with similar boiling points. It is used as a fuel in cars.

KEROSENE

Kerosene is used as a fuel for jet aircraft, as domestic heating oil and as 'paraffin' for small heaters and lamps.



▲ Figure 23.5 Kerosene is used as aviation fuel.

DIESEL

This is used as a fuel for buses, lorries, some cars, and some railway engines. Some is also converted to other more useful organic chemicals, including petrol, in a process called *cracking* (see page 273–275 for more details on cracking).



▲ Figure 23.6 A train powered by diesel

FUEL OIL

This is used as a fuel for ships and for industrial heating.



▲ Figure 23.7 Ships' boilers burn fuel oil.

BITUMEN

Bitumen is a thick, black material, which is melted and mixed with small pieces of rock to make the top surface of roads.



▲ Figure 23.8 Bitumen is used in road construction.

ENVIRONMENTAL PROBLEMS ASSOCIATED WITH THE BURNING OF FOSSIL FUELS FROM CRUDE OIL

KEY POINT

Fossil fuels include coal, gas and fuels derived from crude oil. These all come from things that were once alive.

There are major environmental problems associated with the burning of fossil fuels derived from crude oil. First of all, the carbon dioxide produced when hydrocarbons are burned is a greenhouse gas. Greenhouse gases *trap the heat radiated from the Earth's surface (originally from the Sun)* and many people believe that this could lead to climate change. For more discussion on the greenhouse effect, see Chapter 13.

ACID RAIN: SULFUR DIOXIDE AND OXIDES OF NITROGEN

KEY POINT

Several oxides of nitrogen are involved, including NO and NO_2. They are often given the general formula NO_x.



▲ Figure 23.9 Use of very low-sulfur fuels limits the production of sulfur dioxide, but the spark in a petrol engine causes oxygen and nitrogen from the air to combine to make oxides of nitrogen, NO_x.



▲ Figure 23.10 Trees dying from the effects of acid rain.

Rain is naturally slightly acidic (pH = ~5.6) because of dissolved carbon dioxide. Acid rain is rain with a pH lower than this (pH < 5.6) because of the presence of various pollutants. The pH of acid rain is often about 4.

Acid rain *is formed when water and oxygen in the atmosphere react with sulfur dioxide to produce sulfuric acid (H_2SO_4), or with various oxides of nitrogen, NO_x, to give nitric acid (HNO_3).* SO_2 and NO_x come mainly from power stations and factories burning fossil fuels, or from motor vehicles.

Fossil fuels contain a small amount of sulfur. When the fuel is burned, the sulfur reacts with oxygen, producing sulfur dioxide:

$$S(s) + O_2(g) \rightarrow SO_2(g)$$

Reactions in the atmosphere with oxygen and water can convert this to *sulfuric acid (H_2SO_4)*, a strong acid and an important component of acid rain:

$$2SO_2(g) + 2H_2O(l) + O_2(g) \rightarrow 2H_2SO_4(aq)$$

Note: when sulfur dioxide reacts with water, a weaker acid called *sulfurous acid (H_2SO_3)* is formed:

$$SO_2(g) + H_2O(l) \rightarrow H_2SO_3(aq)$$

In petrol engines, sparks are used to ignite the petrol–air mixture to power the car. The temperature reached in the engine is high enough to allow nitrogen and oxygen in the air to combine to produce oxides of nitrogen. For example:

$$N_2(g) + O_2(g) \rightarrow 2NO(g)$$

These nitrogen oxides can be converted to *nitric acid (HNO_3)* in the atmosphere and therefore contribute to acid rain.

Acid rain is a major problem, mainly because of its devastating effect on trees and on life in lakes. Acid rain kills trees and fish in lakes. In some lakes the water is so acidic that it won't support life at all. Limestone buildings and marble statues (both made of *calcium carbonate*) and some metals such as iron are also attacked by acid rain.

Reaction between limestone and sulfuric acid:

$$CaCO_3(s) + H_2SO_4(aq) \rightarrow CaSO_4(s) + H_2O(l) + CO_2(g)$$

The solution to acid rain involves removing sulfur from fuels (this is usually done for petrol used in cars), '**scrubbing**' the gases from power stations and factories to remove SO_2 and NO_x, and using catalytic converters in cars.

CRACKING

Although most of the fractions from the fractional distillation of crude oil are useful as fuels, some fractions are more useful and more profitable to sell than others.

The amounts of each fraction obtained will depend on the proportions of the various hydrocarbons in the original crude oil, not the amounts in which they are needed. The problem is:

- there are far too many long-chain hydrocarbons, which are not in such high demand and are not as profitable to sell
- there are not enough shorter-chain hydrocarbons that can be used as fuel for cars.

Far more petrol is needed than can be supplied by just separating crude oil into its fractions.

Cracking is a process in which *long-chain alkanes are converted to alkenes and shorter-chain alkanes*. The big hydrocarbon molecules in fuel oil, for example, can be broken down into the smaller ones needed for petrol. A very simple equation could be:

$$\underset{\text{alkane}}{C_{14}H_{30}} \rightarrow \underset{\text{alkane}}{C_{10}H_{22}} + \underset{\text{alkene}}{C_4H_8}$$

HOW CATALYTIC CRACKING WORKS

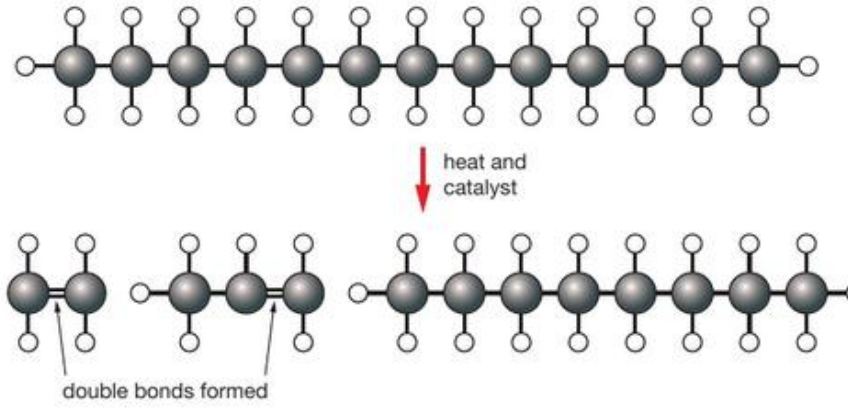
The fuel oil fraction is heated to give a gas and then passed over a catalyst of *silicon dioxide* (also called silica) and *aluminium oxide* (also called alumina) at about *600–700 °C*. Cracking can also be carried out at higher temperatures without a catalyst (*thermal cracking*).

Cracking is just an example of *thermal decomposition*: a big molecule splitting into smaller ones on heating. The majority of the hydrocarbons found in crude oil have single bonds between the carbon atoms. During the cracking process, C–C single bonds are broken and new C=C double bonds are formed.

The molecules are broken up in a fairly random way. One possibility is shown in Figure 23.11.

REMINDER

In Figure 23.11, the molecules have been drawn to show the various covalent bonds. They have also been 'straightened out' with bond angles of 90°.



▲ Figure 23.11 How cracking works.

As an equation, this would read:

$$C_{13}H_{28}(l) \rightarrow C_2H_4(g) + C_3H_6(g) + C_8H_{18}(l)$$

HINT

Don't worry too much if you can't remember which are gases and which are liquids. State symbols are very commonly missed out in organic chemistry.

Cracking produces a mixture of alkanes and alkenes. In this case, two different alkenes are produced: ethene and propene. Octane, an alkane, is also formed. This particular cracking reaction has therefore produced two types of useful molecules for the chemical industry. Ethene and propene are both used to make important polymers, as you will find in Chapter 29. Both are also used in making other organic chemicals. The reaction also produces octane, which is a component of petrol (gasoline).

There are therefore two important reasons why oil companies carry out cracking:

- to produce more petrol
- to produce more alkenes that can be used for making polymers (plastics) (alkenes are more reactive than alkanes and also have other uses).